FREE PARENT CHECKLIST

Is My Child's Speech On Track?

A speech and language development checklist

Milestones by age, warning signs, home tips and when to seek an assessment.

eMbrace Lives

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START HERE

Is my child's speech on track?

Children learn to talk at different speeds, and that is normal. But some patterns are worth checking early, because speech and language therapy works best when it begins young. This checklist helps you see where your child is.

Not a diagnosis

This is a screening aid. A speech-language pathologist can assess your child properly. Use this to decide whether it is time to get a professional opinion.

Speech vs. language: what is the difference?

Speech

How sounds are made: clarity, fluency and voice. Includes articulation and stuttering.

Language

Understanding (receptive) and using (expressive) words, sentences and ideas.

Communication

Using speech, gestures, eye contact and play to connect and share with others.

Why early matters

The brain is most flexible in the early years. Waiting to see if a child will "grow out of it" can mean lost months of support. If you are worried, an assessment is a sensible, low-risk step.

MILESTONES

What to expect, by age

Approximate guide only. Children vary, and bilingual children may mix languages, which is normal.

Age	Typical skills
By 6 months	Coos and babbles, turns to sounds, laughs, makes eye contact.
By 12 months	Babbles with varied sounds ("baba", "mama"), responds to name, waves, points, may say 1–2 words.
By 18 months	Says around 10+ words, points to show things, understands simple requests, follows simple directions.
By 2 years	Around 50 words, starts joining two words ("more milk"), points to body parts, familiar adults understand about half of speech.
By 3 years	Short sentences of 3+ words, asks "what" and "where" questions, strangers understand about 75% of speech.
By 4 years	Tells simple stories, uses past tense, understands most of what is said, speech mostly clear to others.
By 5 years	Full sentences, answers "why" questions, clear speech with few errors, follows multi-step instructions.

Sources include widely used developmental guides such as ASHA and the CDC. For a full picture use our free Child Milestone Checker at embracelives.com/resources/child-milestone-checker.

SELF-CHECK

Checklist by age

Tick what applies to your child now.

Babies and toddlers (0–2 years)

- [ ] Rarely babbles or makes sounds by 9–12 months
- [ ] Does not respond to name or sounds
- [ ] Does not point or wave by 12 months
- [ ] No single words by 16 months
- [ ] Loses words or skills they once had
- [ ] Limited eye contact or shared attention

Toddlers and preschool (2–4 years)

- [ ] Fewer than 50 words at 2 years, or not combining words
- [ ] Hard for family to understand at 3
- [ ] Mostly points or pulls you instead of using words
- [ ] Does not follow simple instructions
- [ ] Repeats words or phrases (echoing) rather than using them to communicate
- [ ] Frustration or tantrums linked to not being understood

Older children (4–12 years)

- [ ] Speech still unclear for their age
- [ ] Substitutes or leaves out sounds (e.g. "wabbit" for rabbit) after age 5–6
- [ ] Stutters or blocks, with visible tension or avoidance
- [ ] Short or jumbled sentences; trouble finding words
- [ ] Struggles to tell a story or explain an event in order
- [ ] Difficulty understanding questions or long instructions
- [ ] Trouble with back-and-forth conversation or making friends
- [ ] Reading or spelling difficulties alongside speech concerns

Voice and hearing (any age)

- [ ] Hoarse, breathy or strained voice that lasts weeks
- [ ] Speech sounds very nasal, or very muffled
- [ ] Frequent ear infections or glue ear
- [ ] Turns the TV up high, or says "what?" often

A note on hearing

Any speech or language concern should include a hearing check. Even mild, temporary hearing loss from ear infections can affect speech development.

MAKING SENSE OF IT

What your ticks might mean

Ticks	What to do
0	Likely on track. Keep talking, reading and playing together.
1–2	Monitor over the next 2–3 months. Use the home tips here. Mention it at your next paediatric visit.
3 or more, or any loss of skills	Book a speech and language assessment. Do not wait.

Common patterns

Pattern	What it can look like
Late talker	Fewer words than expected at 18–30 months. Understands well and plays typically. Some catch up; some do not, so monitor and assess.
Speech sound disorder	Speech is hard to understand or sounds are produced differently from peers of the same age.
Language disorder	Trouble understanding or using words and sentences, often seen with learning difficulties.
Stuttering (fluency)	Repeating, prolonging or blocking on sounds. Common in early childhood; persistent cases benefit from therapy.
Social communication	Difficulty with back-and-forth, eye contact, or using language socially. Can be part of autism or other differences.

AT HOME

Simple ways to support talking

Talk about everything

Describe what you are doing as you do it: "I'm peeling the banana." Keep sentences short and add one word more than your child uses.

Read daily

Point to pictures, name them, ask simple questions. Re-read favourite books; repetition builds language.

Wait and listen

Pause for 5–10 seconds after asking something. Give your child time to respond.

Model, don't correct

If your child says "wabbit," reply "Yes, a rabbit!" Avoid asking them to repeat it.

Play together

Pretend play, songs, rhymes and turn-taking games build both language and connection.

Limit screens

Real conversation is far more powerful than screen time for early language. Aim for talk-rich routines.

Bilingual homes

Speaking more than one language does not cause speech delay. Use the language you are most comfortable with at home. A good assessment looks at all of your child's languages.

What a speech and language assessment includes

- Talking with you about your child's history, play and daily communication.
- Observing play, listening, speech sounds, words and sentences.
- Standardised tools where suitable, and a hearing check recommendation if needed.
- A clear plan: therapy goals, home activities and how often to review.

PRINT AND FILL IN

Speech and language observation log

Over a week or two, note what your child says and does. Bring this to your appointment, and a short video clip of your child talking or playing if you can.

Date / situation	New words or sentences heard	Words hard to understand	How my child communicated

Questions to bring

- Is my child's speech or language delayed, or just different?
- Do we need a hearing test?
- How can we practise at home, and how often?
- What should I share with the school?

NEXT STEP

Take the next step with eMbrace

Little words, big steps. Let's help them find their voice.

If your checklist raises questions, a speech and language assessment can give you clarity and a plan. Our speech-language pathologists work with children and adults in person at both centres, and online.

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Speech therapy	embracelives.com/speech-therapy/speech-therapy
Child milestone checker	embracelives.com/resources/child-milestone-checker
Book an appointment	embracelives.com/appointment

Important information

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